

WE WERE ON THE 19TH FLOOR, AND I JUST DECIDED TO JUMP FROM THE BALCONY

We were locked with Australia in the league with the same number of points, and the replay was decided on penalty strokes. We had lost the first game 6-1 and the replay 5-4 on strokes. At the end of the first match, I made a **dreadful decision** to end my life. I thought I had let the team down.

Ashok Diwan

Winning the 1975 World Cup with a classic triumph over Pakistan in the final in Kuala Lumpur was my most memorable moment on the field. It was epic, as hailed by many of the game's experts. Pakistan was a strong opponent, but we were a determined team with a champion player in each match rising to the occasion.

It was natural for the team to be excited about the Montreal Olympics. We were the world champions and the favourites, and we believed we had a strong team to win the gold. But things went awry when the authorities decided to play the game on artificial surfaces. It turned out to be a big blow to Indian hockey.

At the preparatory camp in Patiala, the Indian experts found a *desi* solution for us. Cow dung was

spread on the entire field, and we were told to practice once it had dried. That was our substitute for astro turf. I ended up with two broken teeth.

We visited Paris a month before the Olympics to get a feel of the astroturf. It was exciting, but some of us got injured due to the fast pace of the surface. One of our seniors had a collarbone injury, but he continued. From Paris, we went to Toronto where we beat New

Zealand in one of the trial matches. New Zealand went on to win the gold at the Olympics. There were some issues related to financial matters. The team officials had collected some money from the locals, but some of the players did not like the arrangement. A letter was drafted to complain to the hockey federation to step in and clear the matter. Some of the senior players were unhappy with the development.



My colleague, Virender Singh, spoke to me and talked me out of the decision. No one knows about that incident. Not even my family. They will learn about it when they read this interview.